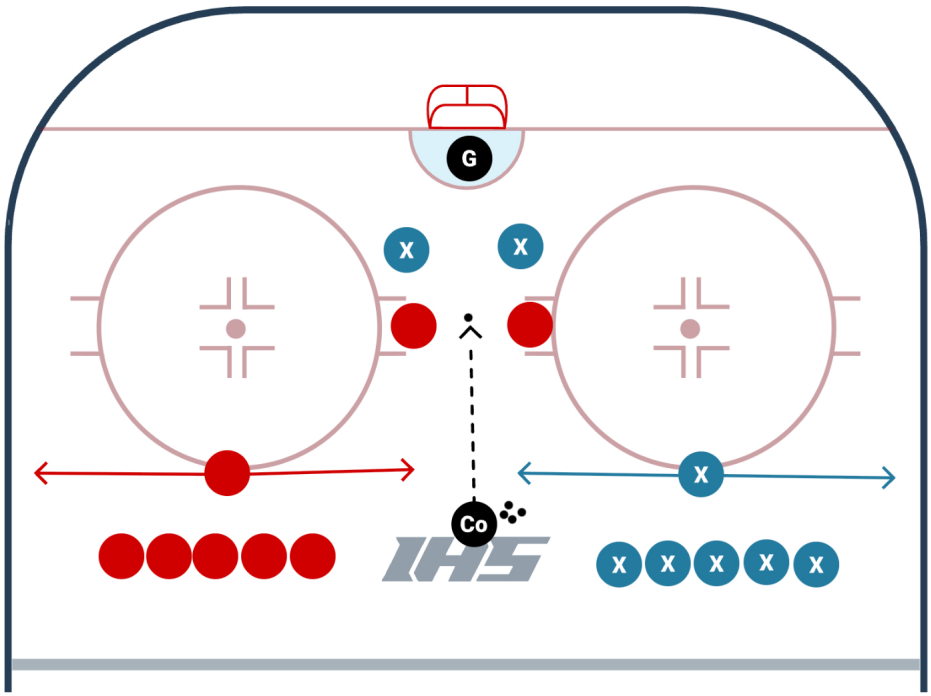
1, 2, 3 BUMPER GAME



Time: **Station:**



The 1-2-3 Bumper Game from Michael Peca was recorded during the 2024-25 NHL Season. It is a small-area game that emphasizes offensive creativity, quick decision-making, and defensive awareness. The drill incorporates a bumper player, encouraging give-and-go plays, puck support, and communication while rewarding strong defensive efforts with transition opportunities.

Setup:

- **Coach Position:**
  - The coach starts the drill with a shot on net, creating a rebound or loose puck battle.
- **Player Positions:**
  - Two X players and two Red players battle in a 2-on-2 scenario for possession.
  - A bumper player is positioned along the top of the zone for both teams, available for offensive support.
- **Bumper Player Rules:**
  - The bumper player cannot play defense and only provides an offensive passing option.
  - They are free to move laterally across the ice to create support.

Execution:

- **Starting the Play:**
  - The coach takes a shot, creating a rebound or loose puck battle.
  - The first team to recover possession begins their offensive attack.
  - **Two options to initiate offense:**
    - The puck can be carried below the goal line before attacking the net.
    - The puck must be passed to the bumper player before an attack can be made.

- **Using the Bumper Player:**
  - The bumper player provides an outlet for passing, allowing for:
    - Give-and-go plays.
    - Quick weak-side one-timers.
    - Resetting offensive pressure if no immediate play is available.
- **Defensive Strategy:**
  - Defenders must protect the middle of the ice, disrupt passing lanes, and anticipate bumper passes.
  - Defensive players focus on closing space, using active sticks, and recovering loose pucks quickly.
  - The New York Rangers' defensive philosophy is used (the 3 D's):
    - Down – Keep sticks on the ice when defending.
    - Disrupt – Be active with stick positioning to block passing lanes.
    - Dislodge – Force turnovers and recover the puck.

Key Teaching Points:

- **Puck Support:** Encourage players to use the bumper player to relieve pressure and create offensive chances.
- **Defensive Awareness:** Defenders must focus on closing space, active sticks, and reading passing options.
- **Communication:** Players must verbalize positioning and passing options to facilitate quick decision-making.
- **Quick Transitions:** Teams must recover pucks and immediately look for offensive options.

Variations:

- Can have the bumper players be lower in the zone (for a smaller playing area), where they are shown in the diagram, or up by the blue line.
- Can make the game 2 on 2 or 3 on 3.